



THE NEW TOUCHABLES: Manjhi (above), Modi (second from left)

temples as well as a cleansing drive to rid these religious bodies of goondas and land-grabbers. Last year, when Kunal was appointed the administrator of BSBRT, he had discovered that about 90 per cent of the temples were directly or indirectly under the control of criminals. He spent a year trying to bring them out of the clutches of musclemen. Having done that, he shifted his attention to the Dalitisation movement.

In fact, the process had started way back in the early '80s when Kunal got involved with the Mahavir temple near Patna railway station. He first helped in the building of the temple through *shramdan* (voluntary labour). On June 30, 1993, as the secretary of Mahavir Mandir, he took a revolution-

ary step by installing a Dalit priest, Phalhari Suryavanshi Das from Ayodhya, as its head.

His move was accompanied by a change in political stance in the state—chief minister Lalu Prasad Yadav's social justice campaign targeting the exploitative nature of the Brahmins was at its peak then. The three highly respected priests—Ramchandra Paramahans, Mahant Avidhyanath of Baba Gorakhnath Dham and Mahant Avadh Kishore Das had put a seal of their approval by supervising the ceremony. Lalu had even gone a step ahead and declared senior Dalit leader Ramai Ram as 'Shankaracharya'. This honour, bestowed on a Dalit leader, worked in Kunal's favour and, in turn, Ram has now promised full support to his campaign. "I welcome and support his (Kunal's) efforts as it will have a

positive impact on the society," he says.

However, Kunal's move faced opposition from many quarters. Angered by the Dalitisation of religious places, Shankaracharya of Puri Nishchalan—and had refused to meet him during the annual Magh Mela in 2004. But Kunal was determined to prove through the vedas, puranas, scriptures and ancient historical text as per Hindu philosophy that Sudras or Dalits always occupied a respectable position in society.

After studying and researching the subject for 20 years, Kunal has now come out with the first volume of his book *Dalit Deva Bhava*. This 700-page tome, punctuated with excerpts from Sanskrit texts, breaks many a myth about the caste factor. Kunal also rejects the theory that Sudras had no right to hear or recite the puranas or the Gayatri Mantra. He proves that tradition was twisted by the Brahminical and feudal sections of society for their own convenience and gain control over Hindu society. "We are trying to create awareness that all restrictions have been imposed without any religious sanction," says Kunal. However, he clarifies, "We don't take a *purohit's* work from a Dalit *pujari* if he is not well-versed with the Sanskrit language. But nobody is barred from performing the rituals."

Kunal's painstaking research also reveals that, contrary to popular belief, all famous temples in the country—Balaji at Tirupati, Jagannath at Puri, Lingaraj at Bhubaneswar and Ranganath at Srirangam in Tamil Nadu—had been associated with Dalits but changes in the social structure subsequently had led to a change in the religious hierarchy. "We have Manusmriti that defines *varna* (caste system) but we also have a Constitution that ensures equal rights to all," he reiterates. Supporting Kunal's research, anthropologist Dr Sachchindra Narayan says Dalit is not a caste in itself but it has often been used in political parlance without its scientific basis being understood. "These words are conveniently used by people for political gains, but society gets nothing in return. So what is happening is a much-needed and long-awaited part of the cycle of social change. And it is better if people take this change in their stride." ■



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RAMAI RAM, DALIT LEADER